



ABOVE: Contrasting foliage

The golden leaves of *Choisya ternata* Sundance ('Lich') provide a glowing contrast with the adjacent rich pink-red *Berberis thunbergii* 'Rose Glow' and dark purple *Cotinus coggygria* 'Royal Purple'.

As well as the evergreen staples like boxwood (*Buxus*), privet (*Ligustrum*), and shrubby honeysuckle (*Lonicera nitida*), which are commonly used, consider colorful deciduous shrubs, like the prickly *Berberis thunbergii* and its cultivars, or the evergreen *Photinia x fraseri* 'Red Robin', which produces fiery young foliage in spring and after clipping.

Certain shrubs are also ideal for topiary, their small leaves lending themselves to detailed shaping. Suitable shrubs include boxwood and shrubby honeysuckle.

Shrubs such as fuchsias, hebes, fatsias, and choisyas are ideal for containers. Pots also limit the size of larger shrubs.



Spring pastels

Ceanothus flowers appear in late spring, decorating the garden with various shades of blue and white. These short-lived evergreens enjoy a warm, sunny site.

Year-round interest

There is a shrub in flower almost every month of the year. Interest begins in spring with a range of colorful varieties, including flowering currants (*Ribes*), ceanothus, and rhododendrons. The display continues with an abundance of summer-flowering shrubs like fuchsias, hydrangeas, buddlejas, and spiraeas, followed in fall by a range of colorful berries offered by plants such as pyracanthas, cotoneasters, and *Skimmia japonica*. Many shrubs retain their fruits into winter, providing birds and wildlife with a much-needed supply of food.

As temperatures fall, the fragrant flowers of witch hazel (*Hamamelis*), mahonias, and winter box (*Sarcococca*) open, bringing new interest to the garden. Combine these with the vivid stems of coppiced dogwoods (*Cornus* species) and variegated evergreens for a dramatic winter scheme.



Feast of berries

The bright red berries of a female *Skimmia japonica*, produced where plants of both sexes are grown together, persist well into winter.

KEEPING SHRUBS IN SHAPE

Many young plants and shrubs, such as daphnes, produce long, leggy growths in spring or early summer after flowering. They do not require major pruning, but a light trim will produce a more compact, bushy shrub that will be covered in flowers the following year.



1 Assess your plant

In early summer, after daphnes have flowered, young leggy shoots sprout from the main stems. Before cutting them back, take a look at the shrub to see where to cut to produce a well-shaped plant.



2 Shorten leggy growths

Using a pair of pruners, shorten the leggy growths by 6–8 in (15–20 cm). It is important that you always prune immediately above a leaf bud with an angled, slanting cut, as shown above.



3 Work around the plant

Circle the plant, shortening each of the whippy stems, and checking that you are maintaining a good shape. The cut stems will then produce bushier growth and more flowers the following year.